

# Data Governance Maturity Checklist: Protect Your Strategic Asset and Prevent Financial Losses

*"Governance for People, Value from Data"*

Data governance is neither a milestone with a completion date nor a departmental project; it is a vital, ongoing corporate function that ensures the availability, integrity, and security of your organization's most strategic asset. Within the DAMA DMBOK2 framework, achieving maturity in this discipline is the only way to prevent financial losses stemming from inefficiency and legal risks, enabling the orchestration of people and technology to generate a tangible return. Without a maturity roadmap, your organization is operating blindly, accumulating technical debt and compliance risks that jeopardize its strategic future.

## 1. The Challenge: Why measure maturity?

In today's environment, ignoring the state of your data means accepting constant operational friction. Organizations that fail to assess their maturity often get trapped in a cycle of data-related "firefighting" caused by:

- **Information Silos:** Departments operating in isolation, creating conflicting versions of reality and duplicating efforts.
- **Compliance Risks:** Critical vulnerability regarding regulations (such as GDPR or local laws) due to a lack of traceability and control over sensitive data.
- **Lack of Ownership and Stewardship:** Accountability gaps where no one takes responsibility for the quality, security, or currency of the asset.
- **Poor Data Quality:** A decision-making foundation undermined by inaccurate information, eroding senior management's confidence in operational reporting.

This checklist is designed to help you lead the transition from chaos to seamless data flow, transforming governance from a bureaucratic burden into a value accelerator.

## 2. Maturity Self-Assessment: The Three Strategic Pillars

Answer each question with professional objectivity to determine your real level of exposure.

### Pillar I: Foundations (Strategy, Roles, and Responsibilities)

This pillar evaluates whether a clear command structure exists to treat data as a business asset rather than a technical byproduct.

| Assessment Question                                                                                                                   | Response<br>(Yes/No) |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| <i>Is there a Data Governance Council or Central Committee with the authority to issue cross-functional regulations?</i>              |                      |
| <i>Have "Data Owners" been formally designated from the business areas with authority over the processes that originate the data?</i> |                      |
| <i>Are "Data Stewards" (functional experts) identified and responsible for managing the business glossary?</i>                        |                      |
| <i>Is the data strategy explicitly aligned with the company's strategic goals and OKRs?</i>                                           |                      |
| <i>Do you have documented policies defining the data lifecycle, from acquisition to final disposition?</i>                            |                      |
| <i>Is there a clear chain of accountability involving senior management in the oversight of the data asset?</i>                       |                      |

## Pillar II: MVP and Tools (Technical Execution and Protection)

Evaluation of tactical capabilities and organizational measures to guarantee integrity and regulatory compliance.

| Assessment Question                                                                                                                                      | Response<br>(Yes/No) |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| <i>Do you have a Record of Processing Activities (ROPA) and an updated inventory of personal data?</i>                                                   |                      |
| <i>Are mandatory Privacy Impact Assessments (PIA/DPIA) conducted for high-risk data processing?</i>                                                      |                      |
| <i>Have automated quality rules been implemented based on the 5 critical dimensions (Accuracy, Completeness, Consistency, Timeliness, and Validity)?</i> |                      |
| <i>Do you implement verifiable technical measures such as data encryption at rest and in transit, or pseudonymization?</i>                               |                      |
| <i>Do you have the technical capacity to respond to ARCO+ rights requests (Access, Rectification, Cancellation, Opposition, and Portability)?</i>        |                      |
| <i>Can you trace data lineage and document its transformations to ensure the transparency required by the regulator?</i>                                 |                      |

### Pillar III: Change Management (Culture and Data Literacy)

Measures the transition from a reactive culture to one of "shared responsibility" and prevention.

| Assessment Question                                                                                                                   | Response<br>(Yes/No) |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| <i>Are there Data Literacy programs so that personnel understand the value and risk of the data they handle?</i>                      |                      |
| <i>Is the use of governed Self-Service tools promoted to mitigate the financial risks of "Shadow IT"?</i>                             |                      |
| <i>Is there a formal and well-known mechanism for reporting security breaches or data quality incidents?</i>                          |                      |
| <i>Is data quality understood as a responsibility of each producing area and not as an exclusive function of IT?</i>                  |                      |
| <i>Does the organization prioritize a "Privacy by Design and by Default" approach in the development of new products or services?</i> |                      |
| <i>Are periodic internal audits conducted to verify the effectiveness of the implemented governance and security controls?</i>        |                      |

### 3. Interpretation of Results and DAMA Maturity Levels

Sum your affirmative responses (1 point for each "Yes") to identify your position according to the DAMA DMBOK2 framework:

- **Level 1: Initial/Ad Hoc (0-3 points):** Fragmented and reactive management in silos. Your organization is a primary target for ex officio audits and sanctioning procedures due to the lack of basic controls.
- **Level 2: Repeatable (4-7 points):** Consistent processes in isolated projects, but without a corporate vision. The risk of inconsistency and sanctions for "serious infractions" remains high.
- **Level 3: Defined (8-11 points):** Organizationally established policies and standards. Data Owner and Steward roles are identified. A solid foundation for a prevention model exists.
- **Level 4: Managed (12-15 points):** Active use of quality metrics and monitoring tools. Regulatory compliance is integrated into operational and analytical processes.
- **Level 5: Optimized (16-18 points):** Culture of continuous improvement. Full automation and business resilience. Complete strategic alignment that minimizes legal risks and maximizes data profitability.

**Strategic Note:** This checklist measures the presence of the fundamentals. Reaching levels 4 and 5 requires not only having these elements in place but also demonstrating consistent performance, automation, and full integration into the company's operational processes.

## 4. Roadmap Towards Compliance and Efficiency

To transition toward a proactive model that protects business continuity, builds trust and data quality, and fosters a truly data-driven culture, we recommend the following immediate actions:

- **Implement a Data Governance Model:** Centralize policies, processes, and the definition of roles and responsibilities. Assign Data Owner and Data Steward roles to data users within the business areas.
- **Designate a Data Protection Officer (DPO):** Act as a liaison with the regulator and ensure that governance remains updated in the face of regulatory changes.
- **Data Quality Automation:** Migrate from manual correction to real-time monitoring based on DAMA dimensions (Accuracy, Completeness, Consistency, Timeliness, Validity).
- **Multi-Regulatory Alignment:** Integrate data governance with current laws and regulations.

## 5. About the Author

**Sandy Bradbury** is a Senior Strategic Data Governance Consultant and a leading specialist in the **DAMA-DMBOK2** framework. His approach goes beyond the technical to focus on the "human side" of data: change management and organizational culture.

As an expert in structuring the dynamics of the people who interact with information, Sandy helps organizations orchestrate technology and processes from end to end. His mission is clear: to transform data from a chaotic liability into a high-value strategic asset, ensuring that technical architecture always serves business objectives and operational efficiency.

## 6. Next Steps: Strategic Diagnostic Session

**Is your organization ready to move beyond merely managing data and start governing it?**

If your maturity level falls short of your goals, or if you are looking to accelerate the transition to an optimized model, I invite you to take the next step. A robust strategy does not stem from technology, but from a clear vision that aligns your people with the value of your assets.

**"Let's discuss how to orchestrate your people and technology to maximize the value of your data."**

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